

The Clock Is Ticking: Trump Wants To Wait - But Iran May Not

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The most dangerous period in the conflict with Iran may not be determined by missiles, aircraft or troop movements. It may be determined by the calendar.

President Donald Trump appears increasingly willing to slow the military tempo and let economic pressure do the work. His administration is preparing what Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has called the "toughest sanctions in history," targeting Iran's oil revenues, financial networks and countries that continue doing business with Tehran. Trump himself recently described the approach as "low-keying it," signaling that, at least for now, he prefers economic warfare to another major round of strikes.

That strategy requires something Washington believes it has: time.

Iran may be reaching exactly the opposite conclusion.

If Tehran believes the sanctions campaign will steadily weaken its economy, limit its ability to rebuild damaged military capabilities and increase internal pressure, then waiting until winter could leave it with fewer options than it has today.

And hanging over both calculations are two dates: Israel holds its national election on October 27. The United States holds its midterm elections exactly one week later, on November 3.

That creates a potentially explosive window in which Washington has powerful reasons to avoid escalation-- and Tehran may have powerful reasons to provoke it.

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Trump's Strategy: Let Time Work Against Iran

From Washington's perspective, another large-scale military offensive carries substantial risks.

It could produce American casualties. It could trigger larger Iranian retaliation. It could further disrupt the Strait of Hormuz and send oil and gasoline prices higher at precisely the moment voters are deciding control of Congress.

Economic pressure offers Trump another option.

The administration believes months of warfare have left Iran substantially weakened and that sanctions may now accomplish what earlier financial pressure could not. The United States can squeeze Iranian petroleum exports, banking relationships and international trade while maintaining military pressure in the background.

The strategy is essentially: Why risk another costly military campaign today if Iran might be significantly weaker several months from now?

There is also an obvious political advantage to patience.

Even if the White House never publicly says it wants to avoid major escalation before November 3, presidents understand that wars are politically unpredictable. A successful operation can strengthen public confidence. A failed raid, captured American soldiers, rising gasoline prices or an unexpected regional escalation can dominate an election overnight.

Trump therefore has every reason to keep his options open while avoiding unnecessary surprises.

Iran, however, understands the same calendar.

Tehran's Problem: Waiting May Only Make Things Worse

Iran must ask a very different question:

What will its position look like after November 3?

If American sanctions become increasingly effective, Iranian oil revenues decline, military equipment becomes harder to replace and Trump emerges from the midterms with fewer immediate political constraints, Tehran could find itself negotiating from an even weaker position.

That creates an uncomfortable strategic possibility.

Iran's best opportunity to create leverage may be before the elections rather than after them.

Mark Dubowitz, CEO of the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, has warned specifically about the possibility of an Iranian "October surprise"--an operation deliberately timed around the Israeli and American elections. His argument is not that anyone knows precisely what Iran will do, but that Tehran has an unusually strong incentive to exploit this narrow political window.

Recent Iranian rhetoric makes the possibility harder to dismiss.

Iranian Army commander Amir Hatami announced a \$30,000 reward for killing or capturing an American service member, reportedly doubling the reward if carried out by a woman. Iranian propaganda has simultaneously featured increasingly graphic threats against American political and military targets.

The question is whether those threats are merely psychological warfare--or preparation for something more.

Iran Doesn't Need To Defeat America

This is where Tehran's potential strategy becomes especially dangerous.

Iran cannot defeat the United States conventionally. But it does not have to.

It only needs to create a crisis Washington cannot easily ignore.

Imagine several possible scenarios.

A significant number of American troops are killed at a regional base.

American service members are captured.

An Iranian proxy conducts a major attack that Washington attributes to Tehran.

Israel suffers a missile attack severe enough that retaliation becomes unavoidable.

Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz is disrupted again, sending oil prices sharply higher.

None of those events would defeat the United States militarily.

But occurring in late October, any one of them could dramatically alter the political environment.

Trump would immediately face a difficult choice: respond forcefully and risk a larger war days before an election, or exercise restraint and face accusations that America had failed to answer an attack.

From Tehran's perspective, forcing Washington to make that choice may itself be a strategic victory.

Israel Could Be The Trigger

Iran would not necessarily need to target Americans directly.

Israel votes October 27, creating another potential pressure point.

A sufficiently damaging Iranian attack against Israel could make a major Israeli response politically and

militarily almost inevitable.

Israel retaliates.

Iran strikes again.

The United States becomes more deeply involved.

Oil prices rise.

And suddenly the American midterms are taking place amid another major Middle Eastern escalation.

That is the essence of the "October surprise" theory: Tehran could attempt to create circumstances in which Israel delivers the escalation Iran wants and Washington becomes trapped by it.

Oil May Be Iran's Most Powerful Political Weapon

There is another option that requires no spectacular terrorist attack.

Energy.

The conflict has already demonstrated how quickly events surrounding the Strait of Hormuz can affect global petroleum markets. Brent crude was trading above \$90 this week as markets continued reacting to tensions over Iranian exports and Gulf shipping.

Tehran understands something very important about American politics: millions of voters who never follow nuclear negotiations or military strategy understand the price displayed at their local gas station.

Disrupt oil supplies sufficiently and a distant geopolitical conflict becomes an immediate household economic issue.

That gives Iran a form of asymmetric leverage far beyond its conventional military strength.

But An October Attack Would Be An Enormous Gamble

There is another side to Tehran's calculation.

An attack designed to politically damage Trump could produce exactly the opposite result.

Americans could rally behind the president after American troops are killed or captured. Congress could support overwhelming retaliation. Israel could respond far more aggressively than Iranian planners anticipated.

And Washington could conclude that Tehran had deliberately attempted to manipulate an American election--removing whatever restraints had previously existed.

Iran therefore has powerful reasons for both escalation and caution.

That is precisely what makes the coming weeks so dangerous.

Two Countries, Two Opposite Clocks

Washington appears to believe:

We can afford to wait because Iran gets weaker with every passing month.

Tehran may increasingly believe:

We cannot afford to wait because we get weaker with every passing month.

Those two conclusions can exist simultaneously.

And when they do, pressure increases for the weaker side to act before its position deteriorates further.

The calendar is now remarkably compressed.

Washington is intensifying economic pressure in late August. September will reveal whether that pressure

begins producing meaningful results. Israel votes October 27. America votes November 3.

Then the political landscape changes.

That makes late September through early November potentially one of the most dangerous periods of the conflict.

Trump's strategy depends on patience.

Iran's strategy may increasingly depend on denying him that patience.

The greatest danger, therefore, may not be that either side deliberately chooses an all-out war.

It may be that Tehran decides its best remaining opportunity is to manufacture a crisis before the clock runs out.

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